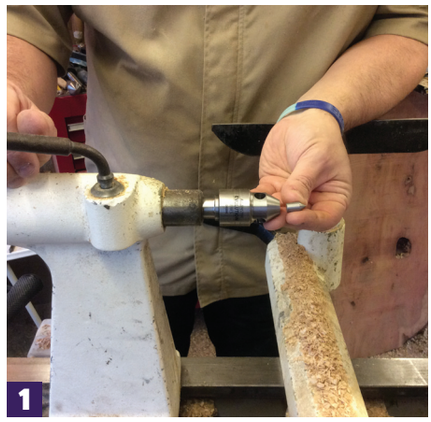
Single-piece lamp

1 It's really important that the hole through your lamp is in the dead centre and the best way to do this is to start by drilling the hole first. To prepare the blank for centring and turning, take the corners away on the bandsaw to give an eight-sided blank. I'm using a large four-prong drive, which needs to be tapped into one end of the lamp first. In the tailstock I'm using a hollow live centre, which consists of a ring and removable centring pin. To start with we use this pin to locate the centre and increase pressure from the tailstock enough so that the ring leaves an impression on the timber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2

2 Here you can see the centre once the pins have been removed and the tailstock has been wound back to its full, which will make a shorter distance to push the auger through. Mount the blank onto the lathe using the ring mark from the live centre. This is a good time to mention a few safety points: turn your lathe down to a low speed for start up, ensure all your levers are tight on the tailstock and the toolrest isn't touching the timber

3

3 The auger I'm using here has a separate cam lock handle, this is ideal for lamps of varying lengths and means you don't need to use the full length of the auger if you're making short lamps. The auger itself has a relief after the main cutting section giving clearance when drilling a long way

4

4 Before you start drilling, it's good to plan out your next moves. I like to start with just enough auger exposed to drill in 100–150mm but make a mental note of how much auger I will need to take me past the halfway point of the lamp, if necessary marking with masking tape on the auger behind the cam lock handle

5

5 My hollow live centre has a set of exhaust holes running around its circumference that allows the swarf to be sent away from the cut using centrifugal force. You'll need to give the centre a helping hand and, as you gently push the auger in, keep easing back to allow the swarf to clear

6

6 This stage of long hole boring can cause problems and should not be rushed. Just cut in 40–50mm at a time, making sure you clear the exhaust holes frequently and lubricate the auger with some wax polish. The wax polish keeps friction down to a minimum and stops any screeching and overheating. Don't be tempted to use machine oils or WD-40 as these will stain the timber. Be very careful when applying the wax as the auger is very sharp and very hot

7 As you can see, I've positioned myself comfortably behind the auger. Relax into it, clear often and have the wax ready. Drill to just past the centre point

7

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